PATIN / TERO!

Section 4 — Characters, Roles, and Signature Movesets
Game Design Document · Reconstructed Draft v1.0 · For review

Section 4 defines playable characters, their roles, signature moveset cards, star-level upgrades, and how character combinations create strategic depth. Character identity is expressed through movement patterns rather than traditional combat statistics or reactive AI. The nine-character roster and 27-card structure are retained; exact original names and command sequences are not fully available, so provisional elements are clearly labeled.

4.1 Character System Overview

PATIN / TERO! features nine character types: four runners, three horizontal guards, and two center guards. Each character has a unique identity and role, three predefined signature cards with four commands each, star level from one to three, and role-specific deployment anchors. The MVP has no conventional attack damage, health points, or equipment inventories.

Category	Characters	Function
Runners	4	Offensive characters
Horizontal Guards	3	Defensive characters on fixed rows
Center Guards	2	Vertical-line defenders

4.2 Character Roles

4.2.1 Runners

Runners are offensive units. Up to three deploy on the offense arena at row-0 starting anchors. They attempt to reach row 7 and return to row 0 without being tagged. Their cards emphasize forward motion, diagonal movement, lane switching, pauses, and TAUNT timing.

4.2.2 Horizontal Guards

Three horizontal guards defend patrol rows 2, 4, and 6. Each moves left and right along its assigned line, using programmed patrol coverage, pauses, and SCARE timing to intercept runners.

4.2.3 Center Guards

One center guard may deploy along the vertical patrol line between columns 1 and 2. It moves up and down that line and intercepts runners crossing between the left and right halves of the arena.

4.3 Character Roster

Provisional roster: The following names and tactical identities are working placeholders to be checked against the original character definitions.

Character	Role	Proposed tactical identity
Habulin	Runner	Direct, forward-focused movement
Liksi	Runner	Diagonal movement and repositioning
Palusot	Runner	Lane switching
Tukso	Runner	Timing disruption and TAUNT
Harang	Horizontal guard	Balanced patrol coverage
Bantay	Horizontal guard	Defensive positioning and pauses
Kapitan	Horizontal guard	Aggressive patrol and SCARE
Sentro	Center guard	Balanced vertical interception
Tanod	Center guard	Controlled coverage and SCARE

Names should evoke Filipino street-game behavior and remain visually recognizable from a slightly isometric camera.

4.4 Signature Moveset Cards

Every character owns exactly three unique signature cards. Each card contains four fixed commands. Players equip and order cards but cannot edit individual commands or transfer cards between characters. A card executes its four commands in sequence, then proceeds to the next equipped card; the complete program loops.

4.4.1 Card Rules

Cards are character-specific, contain exactly four commands, and obey role-compatible command sets. Their order is configurable only during planning, subject to star-level capacity. Two characters may share individual commands while retaining different tactical patterns.

4.4.2 Card Design Philosophy

Cards should express understandable purposes: direct advance, lane changes, timing delays, patrol coverage, defensive pauses, or TAUNT/SCARE opportunities. No card should guarantee victory regardless of the opposing formation.

4.5 Character-Specific Moveset Library

The planned library contains 27 cards: 12 runner cards, 9 horizontal guard cards, and 6 center guard cards. The following card names describe provisional tactical themes; exact four-command sequences are not yet confirmed.

4.5.1 Runner Movesets

Character	Card 1	Card 2	Card 3
Habulin	Direct Advance	Forward Rhythm	Return Sprint
Liksi	Zigzag	Iwas	Paliko
Palusot	Lane Switch	Side Step	Cross Pattern
Tukso	Taunt Step	Delayed Advance	Bait and Move

Runner cards may contain only F, L, R, DL, DR, S, and T.

4.5.2 Horizontal Guard Movesets

Character	Card 1	Card 2	Card 3
Harang	Standard Patrol	Wide Sweep	Return Patrol
Bantay	Hold Position	Short Patrol	Delayed Block
Kapitan	Aggressive Sweep	Scare Patrol	Interception Rhythm

Horizontal guard cards may contain only L, R, S, and C.

4.5.3 Center Guard Movesets

Character	Card 1	Card 2	Card 3
Sentro	Vertical Patrol	Center Hold	Vertical Return
Tanod	Timed Patrol	Scare Line	Vertical Interception

Center guard cards may contain only U, D, S, and C.

4.6 Star-Level Upgrade System

Star upgrades increase programming flexibility rather than speed, attack power, or health. A higher-star unit may combine more distinct signature cards into a longer looping sequence.

Star level	Capacity	Equipment rule
One star	1 card	Choose one of three signature cards
Two stars	2 cards	Choose and order two distinct cards
Three stars	3 cards	Equip and order all three cards

4.7 Character Merging

Three identical units at the same star level merge into one unit at the next star level. Three one-star copies produce one two-star unit; three two-star copies produce one three-star unit. Three stars is the maximum.

4.7.1 Merge Requirements

All three source units must have the same character identity and star level. A merge must not produce invalid deployment or duplicate instances.

4.7.2 Merge Results

The three source units are consumed and replaced with one upgraded unit. The bench and formation update, new card capacity becomes available, and the player may configure the upgraded unit. Which source unit’s deployment anchor and equipped cards are retained is still to be finalized.

4.8 Character Deployment and Role Restrictions

Role	Arena	Valid placement
Runner	Offense	Four starting anchors on row 0
Horizontal guard	Defense	Assigned horizontal patrol-row anchors
Center guard	Defense	Center vertical patrol-line anchors

Dragging highlights only compatible anchors. Invalid drops are rejected and the unit returns to its prior valid position. Star level does not alter role or deployment permissions.

4.9 Moveset Equipment and Execution

4.9.1 Equipment Rules

One-star units run a four-command loop, two-star units an eight-command loop, and three-star units a twelve-command loop. Cards must be distinct and are arranged during planning only.

4.9.2 Execution Example

A two-star runner equips Card A: F → DL → F → DR, followed by Card B: S → F → L → F. The eight-command sequence repeats in that order until the runner or arena resolves. Commands cannot be reordered during battle.

4.10 Character Balance Philosophy

4.10.1 Runner Balance

Direct forward progress should be faster but potentially more predictable; lane switching and delays create alternatives at the cost of time. TAUNT should provide tactical timing without invalidating normal defense.

4.10.2 Horizontal Guard Balance

Frequent movement increases patrol coverage, while pauses can protect particular crossing points. SCARE should complement rather than replace normal patrol.

4.10.3 Center Guard Balance

Because only one center guard deploys, its alternatives should offer meaningfully different vertical timing and coverage. Center guards complement horizontal defenders.

4.10.4 Star-Level Balance

Longer programs offer flexibility but may introduce predictable loops and unfavorable delays. Upgrades should not be automatically superior in every matchup.

4.11 Character Visual Design

4.11.1 General Style

Stylized low-poly 3D characters with exaggerated, readable silhouettes, restrained geometric detail, bright controlled colors, and simple animations suited to the slightly isometric camera.

4.11.2 Runner Design

Agile, energetic silhouettes, lightweight clothing, and clear movement poses; multiple adjacent runners should remain distinguishable.

4.11.3 Guard Design

More grounded, defensive silhouettes. Horizontal and center guard roles should differ through costume, accessories, or shape language—not color alone.

4.11.4 Star-Level Indicators

A small, readable star icon or badge identifies upgrade level without obscuring the board. Upgraded visual effects should remain subtle.

4.12 Character Animation Requirements

Animation	Runner	Guard
Idle	Yes	Yes
Move	Yes	Yes
Direction change	Yes	Yes
STAY	Yes	Yes
TAUNT	Yes	No
SCARE	No	Yes
Tagged	Yes	No
Successful round trip	Yes	No
Victory celebration	Yes	Yes

Animations are visual only and cannot affect authoritative simulation timing or state.

4.13 Character Data Structure

CharacterDefinition: ID, name, role, visuals, and three signature cards. UnitInstance: character reference, star level, equipped cards, card order, and deployment anchor. BattleUnitState: logical position, facing, command index, timing, and active state. Separating static definitions from runtime state supports deterministic replay and multiple copies of a character.

4.14 Character Design Constraints

MVP constraints: exactly nine character types; three cards per character; four commands per card; three star levels; no editing commands within cards; no health/damage system; no reactive combat AI; no undocumented role exceptions; no additional equipment inventory; and no extra active abilities beyond established commands.

4.15 MVP Acceptance Criteria

All nine character names and roles are finalized; 27 cards have valid four-command sequences; role-specific commands and deployment anchors are enforced; multiple copies can be purchased; matching same-star units merge; star capacity works; card equip/order works during planning; invalid configurations are rejected; programs execute deterministically; and characters remain visually distinct at gameplay camera distance.

Section 4 — Items Requiring Confirmation

Before finalizing the implementation reference, confirm the original nine-character roster, all 27 exact signature card sequences, merge inheritance behavior, and the TAUNT/SCARE interaction rules. Provisional names and tactical themes in this document must not overwrite previously finalized character data.